



FULL-BLEED HERO PHOTOGRAPH
RECOMMENDED: ABEL TASMAN / NELSON WATERFRONT

— YOUR JOURNEY BEGINS HERE

Nelson Tasman Relocation Guide

WRITTEN BY ETHICARE RESOURCING · TE TAUIHU



Kia ora, and a warm welcome to Aotearoa.

Kia ora, and a warm welcome to Nelson Tasman — Te Taihū, the sun-soaked top of the South Island.

Nelson is one of New Zealand's sunniest cities, a relaxed arts-and-craft town at the gateway to three national parks and the golden beaches of Abel Tasman. Life here is outdoorsy, creative and unhurried.

This guide covers housing, transport, healthcare, finances and where to explore on your days off.



Lifestyle / welcome photograph

RECOMMENDED: NELSON WATERFRONT OR FAMILY

Nau mai, haere mai ki Aotearoa! (Welcome to New Zealand!)

Ngā mihi nui,
The Ethicare Team

What's inside

01	Welcome & Overview	History, culture, transport and climate	04
02	Healthcare	The health system, GPs, pharmacies, urgent care	09
03	Banking & Finance	Bank accounts, IRD, KiwiSaver, getting paid	11
04	Cost of Living	Prices, an example budget & Sophie's insights	13
05	Housing & Areas	Renting and a guide to the suburbs	16
06	Shopping & Food	Malls, supermarkets, world food, worship	20
07	Recreation & Travel	Things to do, plus weekend trips	24
08	Education & Family	Schooling, zoning, childcare & family life	28
09	Practical Info	Checklists, emergencies, community & phrases	32

— QUICK FACTS

LOCATION

Top of the South Island

CLIMATE

Sunny, mild, sheltered

DRIVE TO CHRISTCHURCH

~5 hours

MAIN CITY

Nelson (~52,000)

MAIN HOSPITAL

Nelson Hospital

NEARBY

Abel Tasman, Golden Bay

New Zealand's sunshine capital

Nelson Tasman sits at the sheltered top of the South Island, regularly recording the country's highest sunshine hours. Nelson, its main city, is a creative, laid-back hub at the doorstep of national parks and beaches.

52K

NELSON RESIDENTS

2,400_{HRS}

SUNSHINE A YEAR – NZ'S
SUNNIEST

3

NATIONAL PARKS WITHIN REACH

Why many professionals enjoy Nelson Tasman

- Often the sunniest spot in New Zealand
- Abel Tasman and two more national parks nearby
- A thriving arts, craft and food scene
- A relaxed, outdoors-first lifestyle

Art, craft and the outdoors

Nelson has long drawn artists and makers, with a celebrated craft scene, galleries and the World of WearableArt born here. The lifestyle is creative, coastal and deeply outdoorsy.

Saturday's Nelson Market is a regional institution, full of local produce, art and craft.

The region is tangata whenua to several iwi of Te Taihū, and its sheltered bays and forests have drawn people for centuries.



Cultural moment

RECOMMENDED: NELSON LANDMARK

“

**Three national parks, the country's best sunshine,
and a town full of makers – Nelson is a lifestyle,
not just a place.**

ON LIFE IN NELSON TASMAN

Getting around

Here is how people get around Nelson Tasman day to day – and what to know about driving in New Zealand.

DRIVING

A car suits the region; State Highway 6 links Nelson, Richmond and Motueka.

BUSES

Local buses serve Nelson and Richmond; the region is compact and easy to navigate.

AIR

Nelson Airport is one of NZ's busiest regional airports, with frequent flights to the main centres.

CYCLING

The Great Taste Trail links the towns, vineyards and coast by bike.

On the road

- New Zealanders drive on the left
- You can usually drive on a valid overseas licence for up to 12 months before converting to a NZ one
- A local transport card makes buses and trains easy
- Keep your overseas licence and any translation handy when you first arrive

A year in the local climate

Nelson Tasman enjoys a sheltered, sunny climate — warm dry summers and mild winters, protected by surrounding ranges. It frequently tops the national sunshine charts.

Summer

DEC – FEB

22–26°

AVG DAYTIME

Autumn

MAR – MAY

17–22°

AVG DAYTIME

Winter

JUN – AUG

10–14°

AVG DAYTIME

Spring

SEP – NOV

15–20°

AVG DAYTIME



Seasonal / scenic photograph

RECOMMENDED: ABEL TASMAN COAST TRACK / SPLIT APPLE ROCK

Sheltered and sunny, with crisp clear winters and warm summers ideal for the beach and the parks. Bring sun protection and a warm layer for evenings.

Healthcare in Nelson Tasman

Health New Zealand | Te Whatu Ora delivers care across the top of the South Island from Nelson Hospital, with Wairau Hospital serving neighbouring Marlborough.

Nelson Hospital

The region's main public hospital — acute, surgical, medical, maternity and emergency services for Nelson and Tasman.

Wairau Hospital (Blenheim)

Serves neighbouring Marlborough with acute and medical care.

Tertiary referrals

Complex specialist cases are referred to Christchurch Hospital, the South Island's tertiary centre.

Private & ACC

Private surgical options operate in Nelson; ACC provides no-fault accident cover for everyone.

Public & private

- Public healthcare is funded through general taxation
- ACC provides no-fault accident cover for everyone
- Private hospitals offer elective procedures and shorter waits
- Many residents hold private health insurance alongside the public system

GPs, pharmacies & urgent care

Registering with a GP and dentist

After you settle in, enrol with a local GP (General Practitioner). Enrolment means subsidised visits — typically around NZ\$50–\$70 when enrolled, more if you are a casual patient. Many practices allow online enrolment once you have an address. Dental care is private; expect roughly NZ\$90–\$150 for a check-up.

Pharmacies

Pharmacies are found throughout the region. Prescriptions are partly subsidised once you are enrolled with a GP — commonly a small standard charge per item.

Emergency & after-hours

- **Emergency Departments** — for urgent or critical care; in an emergency, dial 111
- **Urgent care clinics** — accident & medical clinics offer extended-hours care
- **Healthline 0800 611 116** — free 24/7 advice from registered nurses

Setting up your finances

Getting your finances in order early makes day-to-day life much easier. Most of this can be started before you arrive.

Opening a bank account

The major banks are ANZ, ASB, BNZ, Kiwibank and Westpac. You will usually need your passport, work or resident visa, and proof of a NZ address. Many banks let you start online before arrival, then activate in person. Ask for online banking and a debit card at the same time.

Tax (IRD number)

Every worker needs an IRD number from Inland Revenue. Apply online once you have a NZ address and bank account; processing usually takes around 7–10 working days. Give the number to your payroll team as soon as it arrives so the correct tax is applied. Wages are commonly paid fortnightly.

● Tip

Start your bank account application before you fly — having an account number ready makes your IRD application and payroll setup much smoother.

KiwiSaver & sending money home

KiwiSaver is a government-supported retirement savings scheme. On a work visa you can usually opt in or out. Contributions are a percentage of your pay (commonly 3%, 4%, 6%, 8% or 10%), with employers contributing at least 3%. You can withdraw your funds if you permanently leave New Zealand.

Sending money overseas: banks can transfer internationally, but specialist services such as Wise or OFX are often cheaper and faster. Always compare the exchange rate and the fees before moving larger amounts.

SET UP	WHY IT MATTERS	WHEN
Bank account	Receive salary, pay bills locally	Before / on arrival
IRD number	Be taxed correctly	First weeks
KiwiSaver	Retirement savings + employer top-up	When you start work
ACC	No-fault accident cover	Automatic

What life costs in Nelson Tasman

Nelson's lifestyle appeal keeps housing in demand, with costs below the big cities but reflecting its popularity and sunshine.

\$580/wk

3-BED HOUSE (APPROX. MEDIAN)

\$2.85/L

APPROX. PETROL PRICE

Left

SIDE OF THE ROAD

EVERYDAY ITEM	APPROX. PRICE (NZ\$)
1 litre of milk	\$2.50 – \$3.50
Loaf of bread	\$2.50 – \$4.00
Dozen eggs	\$7 – \$10
Flat white coffee	\$5.50 – \$6.50
Mid-range meal for one	\$25 – \$40
Monthly gym membership	\$60 – \$100
Home broadband	\$75 – \$100 / month

Prices are indicative and change over time – use the calculators at the back of this guide for a personalised estimate.

An example monthly budget

A rough single-person monthly budget for a Nelson Tasman renter. Yours will vary with lifestyle, household size and suburb.

CATEGORY	APPROX. MONTHLY (NZ\$)
Rent (room / small 1-bed)	\$1,300 – \$2,100
Power & water	\$160 – \$240
Internet	\$75 – \$100
Transport / fuel	\$170 – \$290
Groceries	\$450 – \$660
Mobile phone	\$30 – \$50
Entertainment	\$170 – \$330
Estimated total	\$2,400 – \$3,700

Make it personal

- Use Numbeo to compare Nelson Tasman with your current city
- Map your own incomings and outgoings with the Sorted budget planner (sorted.org.nz)

A note from Sophie

A personal word from our Founder on what makes Nelson Tasman special – and who it tends to suit.



● SOPHIE'S INSIGHTS

Nelson is for people who want the outdoors at the centre of their life. The sunshine is real, the national parks are world-class, and the town has a creative, friendly soul.

It's smaller and more remote than the big centres, but for the right person that's exactly the appeal. People who move here rarely want to leave.

Sophie Careem · Founder & Director, Ethicare Resourcing

● From the Ethicare team

Your Ethicare contact is here to help with every step of your move to Nelson Tasman – from accommodation to payroll setup. Reach out any time.

Finding a place to live

From Nelson's central streets to Richmond's family suburbs and Motueka's coastal charm, the region offers relaxed living near the sea and the hills.



Housing / suburb photograph

RECOMMENDED: SUBURBAN STREET OR APARTMENTS

Useful property websites

- trademe.co.nz/property – NZ's largest rental marketplace
- realestate.co.nz – nationwide rentals and homes for sale

A guide to the areas

An orientation to the main areas of Nelson Tasman — each with its own character, price point and who it tends to suit.

Nelson city & The Wood

Central, walkable streets near the cathedral, market and waterfront.

Stoke & Tāhunanui

Suburbs near Tāhunanui Beach, handy to the hospital and airport.

Richmond

The growing Tasman hub with shopping, schools and newer homes.

Motueka & Māpua

Coastal towns toward Abel Tasman, popular for their relaxed village feel.

Across the wider region

Nelson city & The Wood

Central, walkable streets near the cathedral and waterfront.

Stoke & Tāhunanui

Suburbs near the beach, handy to the hospital and airport.

Richmond

The growing Tasman hub with shopping, schools and newer homes.

Motueka & Māpua

Coastal towns toward Abel Tasman with a relaxed village feel.

A tip on choosing

- Think about your commute to work and school zones if you have children
- Where you live can decide which state school your children attend – check the zone before you sign
- Many people rent for a few months first to get to know the areas

Utilities, rates & rubbish

POWER & GAS

Choose from providers like Genesis, Mercury, Meridian and Contact. Compare rates on Powerswitch (powerswitch.org.nz).

WATER & RATES

Council rates fund local services; if you rent, rates are usually included in your rent.

RUBBISH & RECYCLING

Kerbside collection is run by the local council, with separate bins for rubbish, recycling and food scraps.

INTERNET

Most homes have fibre broadband; Spark, One NZ and 2degrees are the main providers.

Set-up quick links

Compare power

powerswitch.org.nz

Post & parcels

nzpost.co.nz

Tenancy advice

tenancy.govt.nz

Where to shop

Nelson Tasman offers malls, town centres and weekend markets. A few of the main ones:

Nelson CBD (Trafalgar St)

The walkable central strip beneath the cathedral.

Richmond Mall

The region's main shopping centre, in Tasman.

Montgomery Square

Home to the famous Saturday Nelson Market.

Markets

The Nelson and Motueka Saturday markets for produce, art and craft.

Supermarkets & groceries

New Zealand's supermarkets fall into a few main groups. Knowing the difference helps you balance budget and convenience.

Pak'nSave

The cheapest of the big chains — a no-frills, bulk-buy warehouse format. Best for budget shopping.

Woolworths

Mid-range and widespread, with strong online shopping and delivery (formerly Countdown).

New World

More upmarket, with a wider fresh and specialty range.

Four Square & FreshChoice

Smaller neighbourhood stores for convenience and top-ups.

Nelson and Richmond have Pak'nSave, Woolworths and New World; Motueka and smaller towns have New World and Four Square. Bring your own bags — single-use plastic bags are banned.

Specialty & international food

One of the joys of settling into Nelson Tasman is finding the flavours of home — or exploring new ones.

Halal & South Asian

A smaller selection in Nelson; many supermarket meat lines are halal-certified — check the label.

Asian groceries

Asian supermarkets and eateries serve the central city.

World food & markets

Nelson's strength is its fresh local produce, seafood, craft beer and markets.

Smaller independent stores open and close over time — a quick search for "halal butcher near me" or your home cuisine will surface the current options near your suburb.

Places of worship

Nelson Tasman reflects New Zealand's spiritual diversity, with welcoming communities across many faiths.

Nelson has Christian churches of many denominations, a mosque, and Hindu and Buddhist communities.

Finding your community

- Most faith communities list service times and locations online
- Many warmly welcome newcomers and visitors
- They can be one of the quickest ways to build a support network when you arrive

Three national parks on your doorstep

Nelson Tasman is an outdoor paradise — golden beaches, alpine lakes and forest trails, with Abel Tasman, Kahurangi and Nelson Lakes all within reach.



Recreation hero photograph

RECOMMENDED: ABEL TASMAN COAST TRACK / SPLIT APPLE ROCK

Don't-miss experiences

- Kayak or walk the Abel Tasman coast track
- Swim at golden-sand Kaiteriteri Beach
- Browse the Saturday Nelson Market
- Explore the alpine lakes of Nelson Lakes

Ten things not to miss

A starter list to get to know Nelson Tasman and the wider region.

- 1 Abel Tasman coast track**
Kayak or walk NZ's most popular coastal trail.
- 2 Kaiteriteri Beach**
Golden sand and turquoise water near the park.
- 3 Saturday Nelson Market**
A regional institution for produce, art and craft.
- 4 Nelson Lakes**
Alpine lakes and walks at St Arnaud.
- 5 Centre of New Zealand**
Walk to the geographic centre above the city.
- 6 Split Apple Rock**
The iconic rock formation near Kaiteriteri.
- 7 Founders Heritage Park**
A village of historic buildings and craft.
- 8 Tahunanui Beach**
The city's long, family-friendly beach.
- 9 Golden Bay & Farewell Spit**
Over the hill to Tākaka and the spit.
- 10 World of WearableArt**
The Nelson-born art and classic car museum.

Travel from Nelson

Nelson Tasman is a great base for exploring. Some favourite weekend escapes:

Golden Bay (~1.5 hrs)

Tākaka, Farewell Spit and Wharariki Beach.

Marlborough (~1.5 hrs)

Blenheim's wine country and the Sounds.

Kahurangi & Nelson Lakes

National-park hiking on the doorstep.

Picton & the Sounds (~2 hrs)

Gateway to the Marlborough Sounds.

Flying onward

- Domestic flights reach the main centres in around 1–2 hours
- Book early for the best fares on Air New Zealand and Jetstar
- Many regions are also linked by scenic road and rail journeys

Schooling & study

Nelson Tasman offers a full range of early childhood education, schools and tertiary study.

Early Childhood Education (ECE)

Kindergartens, daycare, Montessori, kōhanga reo and home-based care for ages 0–5. Government 20-hours funding applies for ages 3–5.

Primary & intermediate

State, state-integrated and private schools for Years 1–8.

Secondary

Years 9–13, working towards NCEA, the national qualification.

Tertiary

Universities and institutes of technology across the country.

School terms run late January to mid-December, in four terms with two-week breaks in April, July and October.

School zones come first

In New Zealand, where you live usually determines which state school your children can attend. For many families, the school decision leads the choice of where to rent or buy.

In-zone = guaranteed

Children living inside a school's enrolment zone are guaranteed a place at that school.

Out-of-zone = ballot

If you live outside the zone you can still apply, but places aren't guaranteed – popular schools run a ballot for limited spots.

Zones are street-by-street

Boundaries can run down the middle of a street, so check the exact address.

● **The order that works best**

1) Shortlist schools you like → 2) Check each school's zone map → 3) Search for rentals inside that zone → 4) Confirm the address is in-zone before you sign.

Childcare for working families

Early childhood (0–5). Daycare, kindergartens, Montessori and home-based care are widely available. The government's 20 Hours ECE funding subsidises care for ages 3–5 at participating centres.

Before & after school (OSCAR). Many schools and providers run breakfast clubs, after-school care and holiday programmes. Subsidies may be available through Work and Income for eligible families.

TYPE OF CARE	APPROX. COST (NZ\$)
Full-time daycare (under 3)	\$350 – \$450 / week before subsidies
20 Hours ECE (ages 3–5)	Up to 20 hrs/week subsidised; extra hours charged
After-school care (OSCAR)	\$5 – \$15 per afternoon, varies by provider
School holiday programme	\$40 – \$60 per day, activity-based

Costs are indicative and vary by provider and suburb. If you'll work shifts, ask providers about flexible hours.

Nelson Tasman for families

Beyond school and work, Nelson Tasman is an easy, outdoorsy place to raise a family.

FREE & OUTDOORS

Beaches, the Maitai River and national parks — much of the fun is free.

RAINY-DAY OPTIONS

The Nelson Provincial Museum, WOW museum and Natureland.

LIBRARIES & PLUNKET

Free libraries run children's programmes; Plunket supports young families.

GETTING AROUND

A relaxed, sunny region — short drives between beaches and parks.

Settling kids in

- Children often settle fastest through school, sport and weekend activities
- Local clubs — football, netball, rugby, swimming — are inexpensive and welcoming
- They're a great way for the whole family to meet people

Pre-departure checklist

Work through these before you fly. Keep digital and printed copies of everything important.

Documents

- ☐ Passport + valid NZ visa (printed too)
- ☐ Job offer & employment contract
- ☐ Qualifications & certificates
- ☐ References & employment history

Money & travel

- ☐ Apply online for a NZ bank account
- ☐ Documents ready for your IRD number
- ☐ Confirm airline baggage allowance
- ☐ Book temporary accommodation

Your first weeks

- | | |
|---|--|
| ☐ Move into your accommodation | ☐ Open / activate your bank account |
| ☐ Apply for your IRD number | ☐ Get a NZ SIM card |
| ☐ Register with a local GP | ☐ Set up power, water and internet |
| ☐ Learn your transport routes to work | ☐ Save 111 and Healthline in your phone |
| ☐ Find your nearest pharmacy & supermarket | ☐ Explore your local neighbourhood |

● You're not alone

Your Ethicare contact is here to help with any of these steps – from accommodation to payroll setup. Reach out any time.

Key numbers & contacts

In any emergency – police, fire or ambulance – dial **111**.

Emergency & health

Emergency	111
Healthline	0800 611 116
Mental health	Call/text 1737
Police (non-urgent)	105

Everyday services

Tax (IRD)	ird.govt.nz
Immigration	immigration.govt.nz
AA roadside	0800 500 222
Local council	govt.nz/organisations

Banks

ANZ	anz.co.nz
ASB	asb.co.nz
BNZ	bnz.co.nz
Kiwibank	kiwibank.co.nz
Westpac	westpac.co.nz

Community & expat groups

One of the quickest ways to settle in is to find your people. Nelson Tasman has active communities for almost every interest and background.

Facebook groups

Search for groups like "Expats in Nelson Tasman", your home-country community, and local suburb buy/sell and parents' groups.

Meetup & interest groups

Meetup.com lists hiking, sport, hobby and newcomer groups — a relaxed way to meet people.

Sports & cultural clubs

Local football, netball, rugby and cricket clubs, plus cultural and faith communities, all welcome newcomers.

Workplace networks

Many hospitals and employers have social clubs and buddy systems for new and international staff.

Rainbow / LGBTQ+ community

- New Zealand is welcoming and progressive — marriage equality has been law since 2013
- There are strong legal protections against discrimination
- OutLine Aotearoa offers rainbow mental-health support (0800 688 5463)

Everyday Māori & Kiwi phrases

Te reo Māori is part of everyday life, and Kiwis have their own slang too.

Te reo Māori

Kia ora Hello / thanks

Nau mai, haere mai Welcome

Whānau Family

Hauora Health & wellbeing

Manaakitanga Hospitality, kindness

Mōrena Good morning

Ka kite anō See you later

Tamariki Children

Ngā mihi nui Many thanks

Aotearoa New Zealand

Kiwi slang

Sweet as Great / no worries

Keen Up for it

Dairy Corner shop

Jandals Flip-flops

Flatting Shared renting

Chur Cheers / thanks

Heaps Lots

Togs Swimwear

Shout Your turn to pay

Knackered Tired

Work out your cost of living.

Use these tools to estimate what life in Nelson Tasman would really cost for you and your family.

Cost-of-living calculators

Compare cities (Numbeo)	numbeo.com/cost-of-living
Budget planner (Sorted)	sorted.org.nz/tools/budget-planner
Living-costs data (Stats NZ)	stats.govt.nz
Take-home pay (IRD)	ird.govt.nz

We hope you've found this guide useful. Moving to the other side of the world is a big step, and there's a lot to take in – so please don't feel you have to have it all figured out at once.

Whatever stage you're at, we're always happy to talk anything through – the big decisions or the small worries. Just reach out to your Ethicare contact whenever you need us.

Ngā mihi nui

The Ethicare team



ETHICARE RESOURCING

Ethicare Resourcing Ltd

Office 1, One Coldbath Square, London, EC1R 5HL · Company No: 14646354

T +44 7375 019 544 · **E** hello@ethicareresourcing.com · **W** www.ethicareresourcing.com